



Holding their ground

ARVN artillerymen reload a 105 mm gun on May 6, 1968, inside the strategically important Phu Tho racetrack. Once a horse racing venue enjoyed by French officials, the track in western Saigon was later used to land helicopters.

Fall of Kham Duc

After the first phase of the Tet Offensive, Kham Duc in the Central Highlands west of Da Nang was the only remaining US Special Forces base along the Ho Chi Minh Trail. On May 10, the Viet Cong attacked and overran Ngok Tavak, an outlying post manned by a small Australian unit. Fearing that a major assault was imminent, airborne US reinforcements were rushed to protect Kham Duc.

By the morning of May 11, the base was completely surrounded by Viet Cong and NVA forces, who unleashed a blistering rocket and mortar attack on the base. Coinciding with the barrage, they began to capture isolated hilltop outposts around Kham Duc.

Determining that it was not as easily defensible as Khe Sanh, General Westmoreland and the US high command decided to evacuate the base. Surrounded, outmanned, and outgunned, the US executed a chaotic air evacuation of more than 1,500 personnel as B-52 strikes, close air support, and helicopter gunships kept the communists at bay. Nine US aircraft were lost to enemy fire during the evacuation. Major Bernard L. Butcher's C-130 transport plane was shot down, killing around 150 Vietnamese women and children as well as the American aircrew. Despite such setbacks, the US evacuation was punctuated by a conspicuous act of gallantry when Lieutenant Colonel Joe M. Jackson landed his C-123 under heavy fire on the airfield to retrieve three members of a combat control team who had been left behind. He was awarded the Medal of Honor for this heroic action.